

## THE MIGHT OF GIDEON

By Christopher Joshua Alexander

The heavy oak-beam struck the threshing floor,  
Deep in the shadow where the grapes were pressed;  
A hidden youth behind a closed wooden door,  
With terror beating in his dust-streaked chest.  
The Midian hooves were thunder on the plain,  
To reap the barley and to burn the yield,  
While Gideon beat the solitary grain,  
A thief within his father's stolen field.

*"Rise, man of valour," spoke the sudden flame,*

Where beneath the terebinth the stranger stood.

He called the smallest by a royal name,

And pulled the coward from the shadowed wood.

Not by the thirty thousand sword-bound men,

Nor by the armour of a boasted king,

Would Heaven break the desert's iron den-

But by the weak, the small, the trembling thing.

He trimmed the army to three hundred spears,

Men who lapped water with an open eye,

Unarmed against a sea of ancient fears,

Beneath the blackness of the midnight sky.

No steel was drawn upon the rocky height,

No shields were clashed; no heavy spears were thrown-

Only a red torch burning in the night,  
Locked deep within a shell of brittle stone.

Then came the shout across the startled hill:  
The sound of clay crushed under sudden hand!  
Three hundred pitchers shattered, sharp and shrill,  
And poured their hidden fire across the land!  
The darkness broke; the enemy turned to flee,  
Confounded by the light they could not tame-  
For God had cracked the vessel on the knee,  
To let the universe behold His flame.

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